

Steven Spielberg doesn't want to do that movie. But a second agent comes along who says, "This is going to be a movie about the sinking of a great ocean liner. It hits an iceberg and starts to sink, and we'll see everybody running around in a panic and doing incredibly heroic and romantic things in the face of overwhelming danger." Everybody will say, "Great! I want to see that movie. I want to see it twice."

Disasters and tragedies and explosions and wars are much more interesting than hard work and building ships and factories and skyscrapers. Earthquakes are more dramatic than civil engineering.

So predictions of economic collapse sell more books. They sound very sophisticated, too, because they are filled with these impressive reasons why another 1929 is inevitable. The authors' explanations sound very logical and compelling. Optimists aren't compelling. They don't have a lot to say. And they sound naive. "Why are you optimistic?" "Well, things aren't so bad. On the whole, the world's getting better. People are working and building their companies. They're getting along and it will be all right." Who wants to buy a book that says, "Don't worry, be happy"?

No, the audience wants the thrill of impending doom. "Who knows?" everyone thinks. "Maybe these people will prove right." Bad things certainly happen with enough frequency in this world. As a friend of mine likes to say, "There are people dying today who have never died before."

But even though bad things happen to companies, industries, even the economy as a whole for a time, somehow society as a whole still moves forward. Problems usually get solved. Recessions end. Somehow the country stumbles on and companies continue to make a profit. If you don't need to put your hands on your money for a few years, I'd say stocks are still the best place to keep it.